



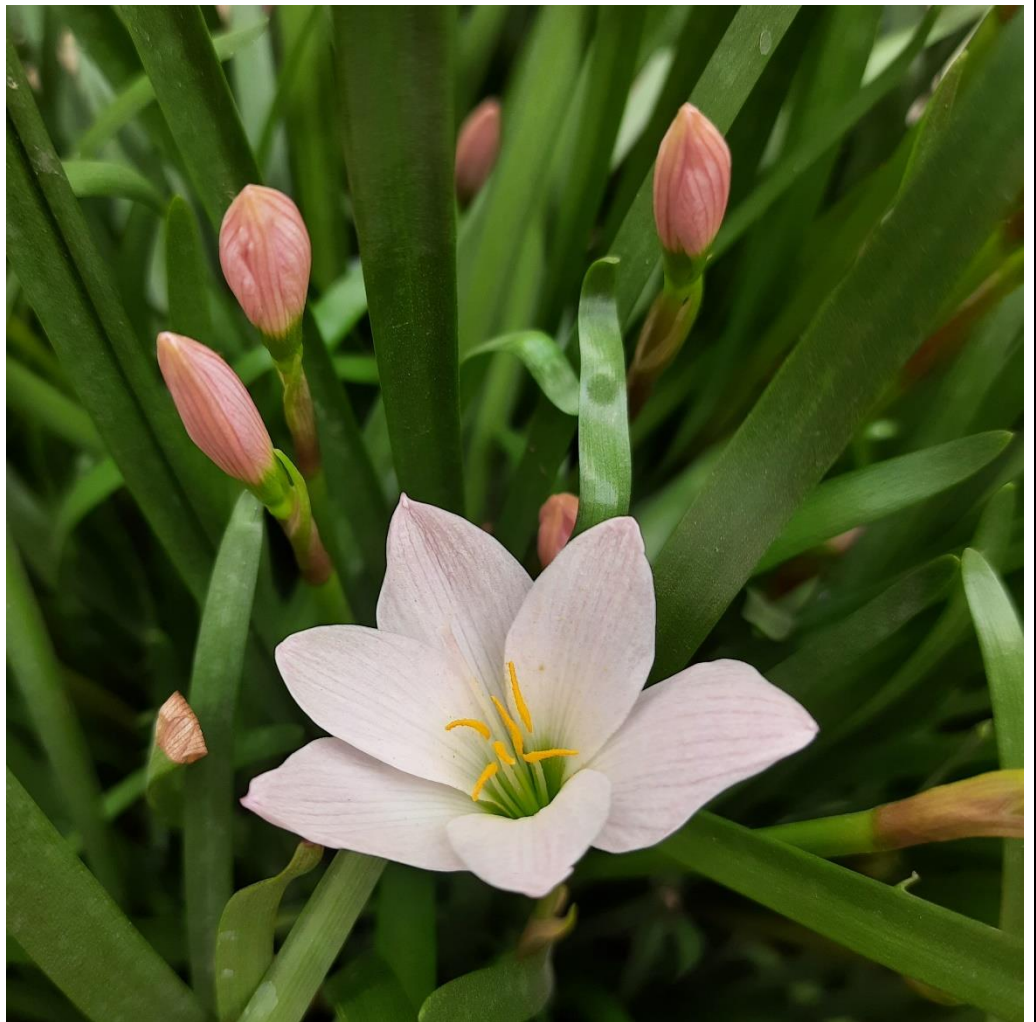
YTA Yoga Tantra & Agama

Newsletter

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From the Chief Editor's desk



Yoga is defined as the union of the empirical soul drowned in the mire of Maya -with the absolute principle or the परप्रमाता parpramata . This is a unilateral process since Shaivites believe that the empirical soul is also a manifestation of the absolute one and it is only owing to his power of veiling himself that the absolute principle plays the role of a conditioned experiencer.

The means of realizing the eternal self is removal of the taints which cause the aberration of conditioning duality and pursuance of projections, impressions pre existent in the causal body . These require different gradations of intensity of induction of spiritual power since the competence varies according to the magnitude of each one of these three taints - called as Mala or impurities . The entire gamut of agamic and tantrik yoga emphasises on various methods of removal of taints . Since there are innumerable gradations according to the temperament and situation of a soul along side the Bhuvana categorisation of the six specifications of the universal phenomena - there are as many upayas as the aspirants or the categories of aspirants .This makes the yoga of the tantras and the agamas different from the conventional yoga of Patanjali and his following corollaries . The tantras propagate this legacy of “easy to practice” knack which yield the same result as the conventional one whereas the Agamas theorise and philosophise on these lines in order to discursively establish their raison de etre’.

It requires a guru to impart spiritual energy which can help the aspirant dispel his misgivings of being a conditioned experiencer .Tantras contain the details of various procedures which are devised to suit the competence and bent of an aspirant. Agamas take care of the possible lure by other cults which inevitably conflict the aspirants commitment so all these three can be grouped together . There are some trends in which yoga and tantra are categorised separately and agamas are studied independently. Discussing the suffixes ल्युट and घञ् yabhijna Maheshwara Abhinavgupta in his exposition Ishwar Pratyabhijna vritti has made the difference clear by referring to संप्रमोषः erasing and संप्रमोषणम् the process of erasing of the memory of an experience . Tantrik canons propound Maheshwara the great lord with Shaktis named memory, knowledge and oblivion (स्मृत्यपोहनशक्तिमान्), the last one is also an expression of his tirodhaan shakti which veils his magnanimity . Memory is defined as the absence of erasing of the experience of an object . The process of erasing is deliberate in Parameshwara hence the term सम्प्रमोषणम् . Patanjali's school uses the term सम्प्रमोषः. Although the similarity has been proven by Abhinavgupta as per Panini's axioms still both can not be synonymous . Sampramosha which is rather a spontaneous process unless reinforced by some counteracting factor like repetition ,maze or familiarising etc. Not only yoga but also similar theistic and atheistic schools of thought have been refuted by

the illustrious exponents of shaivite and agamic lineage merely to assert the pragmatic feasibility and contemporary ness of “सुखोपाय”- the easy way . It is evident that they were well aware of falling into the abyss of never ending trail of assertion and rejection which is why all tantrik and agamic canons are essentially esoterically arcane and seldom exoteric.

Swami Paranand Tirth

Founder President CEO

YTA Yoga Tantra and Agama (inc) Cal. USA

Yoga Tantra et Agama Centre Montreal Quebec CAN



Editorial

According to the Saiva Agamic texts yoga or the union with the supreme self is nothing but a process of recognizing or remembering what has been forgotten consciously through various upayas and means conducive to the aspirant. Now the question arises what is the need for 'conscious forgetting' or if the supreme being exists everywhere in everyone than why isn't it evident? This play of sort reminds me of the game of hide and seek which a parent lovingly plays with his/her child. The parent is hidden and the child is looking for him hither and thither, sometimes thinking he has found the latter only to realize he was mistaken, and then lo behold! Suddenly comes a moment when the child will find the parent and the joy and thrill the child experiences will be unmatched. Agamas tell us that it is to seek this joy of finding what has been hidden consciously which gives rise to the divine play, to the five fold acts of Shiva and his saktis. Without this play there would be no creative flux, no intense poetic representations of longing, no visual and verbal expressions of pangs of separation, no tears of love and no vision of ecstatic pleasure. Can we imagine such a world, a world bereft of art. Explaining the nature and importance of Dynamic Śiva, Abhinavagupta suggests in Tantraloka

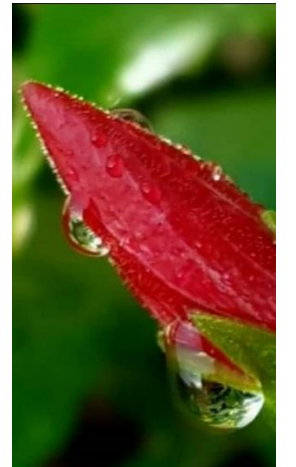
“If the highest reality did not manifest in infinite variety but remained cooped up within its solid singleness it would neither be the highest power nor Consciousness, but something like a jar”

**“अस्यास्यैकरूपेण वपुषा चेन्महेश्वरः ।
महेश्वरत्वं संवित्त्वं तदत्यक्ष्यद् घटादिवत् ॥”**

Explaining the importance of the term संप्रमोषणम् the process of erasing of the memory of an experience consciously by Parameshwara our Guru Maharaj Swami Paranand Tirth ji in his enlightening editorial talks about the methods and knacks which can help an aspirant realize the unison. It requires a guru to impart spiritual energy which can help the aspirant dispel his misgivings of being a conditioned experiencer.

Next we have Swamiji's translation and exposition of 2nd verse of 'Neel Saraswati Stotram' from 'Brihanneel Tantra'. Ma Tara's ferocious form is described and the symbolism of the iconographical features like serpent ornaments, tiger hide and garland of freshly severed human skulls is discussed.

Following this we have the translation and exposition on two sutras (11th and 12th) of Pratyabhijna Hrdayam by Kshemraj from the YTA study circle. The issue ends with a soulful poetic rendition by Prof. Ambika Talwar titled 'Spider and I weave our dreams.'



NEEL SARASWATI STOTRAM**(A Hymn to the sapphire goddess of wisdom from Brihanneel Tantra) Cont.**

Semiotic depictions of metaphysical phenomena .

खर्वे गर्वसमहपूरिततनो सर्पादिभूषोज्ज्वले
 व्याघ्रत्वक्परिवीतसुन्दरकटिव्याधूतघण्टाङ्किते।
 सद्यःकृत्तगलद्रजःपरिलसन्मुण्डद्वयीमूर्धज-
 ग्रन्थिश्रेणिन्मुण्डदामललिते भीमे भयं नाशय ॥ ३॥

You are petite and your profile bears an aura of dignity, you are bright and lustrous with your serpentine ornaments. Your shapely waist is draped in tiger hide and bright polished bells adorn your belt. Your necklace is made from recently severed human heads with blood still dripping from them while they are tied with their hair to one another. O ferocious and yet beautiful mother, dispel my fears.

Petite: A very ancient school of thought opines that words were in fact alphabet so every alphabet also called Matrika (unknown mothers of expression) are the basic quantum for the conveyance of knowledge . The ‘kan’ suffix in this word is sometimes depicted as pertaining to small hence the small mothers . Habitus of the feminine principle led to the concept of mother Tara as a petite figure, neither a midget nor a towering one but a small woman who contains the entire universal phenomena within her womb . खर्व is small in stature as well as magnitude and therefore a relative notion.

Vanity or confidence as a means to scholastic accomplishment पंडितोहममिति भावयेत्
 She has been worshipped as a calibre booster in the area of learning and creativity.
 There is a popular adage -“ *you are lax in grammar and logic this means that you have not adored Tara the goddess of all learning* “तारानाराधिताभवता Grammarians maintain that all notions are pervaded by word and word is a unit of expression or vak

Serpent ornaments: Tara wears serpentine ornaments which on one hand suggest her subjugation of worldly poisons and her physical and spiritual healing power on the other could also refer to the movement of various Pranas in the body. Akshobhya Shiva, her consort is seen as a coiled serpent resting in her hair locks. Snakes are also seen as powerful symbols of transformation and as adornments on Ma Tara they could also refer

to sublimation of various desires and worldly yearnings.

Mystery of the tiger hide: Unlike Ma Kali Tara Ma is seen wearing a lower garment made of tiger skin. In the Daruvan story Siva is seen as an irresistible yogi who skins the tiger sent by rishis enraged by him. This skin since then is used by Shiva as a garment/asana and symbolizes the victory of the divine force over animal instincts. Tiger is one of the most formidable and dangerous animals which features in mythological lore all over the world. The tiger symbol is associated with power, passion, ferocity and sensuality. In addition to these it represents beauty and speed, cruelty and wrath and its appearance in dream is usually a sign of new power or passion that has awakened within an individual in various cultures. It is believed that Guru Padmasambhava arrived in Bhutan on the back of the Tigeress, who was an emanation of Yeshe Tsogyal and hence the place, one of the most important pilgrimage sites is known as Taktsang or the Tiger's cave.

Recently Severed bleeding heads:

Recently Severed bleeding heads tied to form a garland are seen symbolically to represent the letters of Sanskrit alphabet and thus the one who is adorned by them is the concentrated form of all the knowledge as seen as Shabda Brahma, ultimate reality recognized as the sound. Ma Nilasaraswati bestows on her devotees the fruits of poesy and eloquence thus she is clearly the goddess of learning and holds the Matrka shakti within her.

The importance of this concept can be seen in Hesychasts too who saw in the word the essence of the phenomena, hence a word designating a sacred phenomenon became automatically sacred hence the concept that the 'Word of God had become the person of Jesus of Nazareth.' Another theory suggests the eternal word had descended in the person of Jesus, similar to the way in which spirit had descended on the prophets but in a more intimate and complete manner.

Fury for dispelling furious fear

A lot has been written about the fearful forms of both Hindu and Buddhist gods and goddesses. Fury and Fear both are classified in Natyashastra among the eight latent psychological states of the human mind. The world of art helps an individual to come face to face with extreme emotions both negative as well as positive and to purge them through the process of Catharsis. The fearful form of Ma Tara is a reminder for the devotees to see the phenomenal world for what it is and not get too attached to it. Relishing without getting attached is like watching a horror film on screen and experiencing trepidation, goose bumps on one's body and yet enjoying the drama. The aesthetic distance guarantees safety in case of art. Similarly a distanced view can endow one with tremendous power over situations which might prima facie seem frustrating. The feeling of helplessness can be replaced with a feeling of total surrender and acceptance which helps one be in control of the situation.

To be continued .

English rendering and exposition by

Varni Paratpar swarup

Pratyabhijna made easy 11th and 12th Aphorism

Sutra: Aabhasan Rakti Vimarshan Bijasthapan Vilapan tastani

Meaning: Of Manifestation, Relishing, Self consciousness, Seeding and Superimposition

Exposition:

The secret behind aabhasan, rakti vimarshan bijasthapan vilapan and how they are connected to five fold functions of Shiva.

The five functions explained according to Maharathmanjari

Srishti: Whatever appears in the order of expansion of 'Drigdevi' the goddess of subjective awareness is called srishti or is said to have been created i.e aabhasan

Sitithi: Goddess of sustenance sustains when the creation remains in the abode of prshanta for a time fraction, then it is said that the goddess of sustenance has maintained i.e rakti

Samhar: The phenomena created and sustained thus is dissolved during the chamatkara or devouring which is also a synonym of vimarsha or 'subjective gnosis'. This dissolution is called Samhara i.e vimarshan

Ramakantha explaining this complex looking phenomena says, “ *The boulder or mountain of duality is hard to break even in the trance of superconsciousness. This hard Vajra (weapon) of duality, O Shiva is apprehended and destroyed by those who have the power of your devotion.* ”

This real samhara is accomplished by vimarsha or chamatkara (to eat or chew) of multiplicity. The impressions of dissolved phenomena crop up again, even during dissolution. This state with phenomena as dormant in it and ready to crop up again is called superimposition. Since this is repeated so the phenomena situated is within or is different and goes through a continuous cycle i.e. bijasthapan. This superimposition which thrusts the samsara again by concealing the real nature of self is Vilaya.

But when the same phenomena which is experienced is successively assimilated into the fire of consciousness or Chidagni by the method of Hathpak or Alamgras (engulfing in one morsel), this leads to the gnosis of completion and thus is the fifth kritya i.e. Anugraha.

Now you see that these five functions are carried out spontaneously but before a Guru points them out they remain unnoticed. The only way to go about is to serve the Guru. Those who do not serve their Guru can't learn this mystery and therefore are always deluded by their own shaktis.

Questions

1. These parables like avabhasan rakti etc of creation sustenance dissolution etc have been taken from

- a) Swachhanda Tantra
- b) Malini vijaya
- c) Maharth manjari
- d) Originally from pratyabhijna

2. Vimarshana is dissolution because during vimarsha the objectivity is assimilated

- a) True
- b) False
- c) Can't say

3. Bijavasthapanam is

- a) sowing the seeds
- b) putting them aside for sowing
- c) settling so that they dont germinate
- d) none of the above .

4 The means for pulverising the boulder of duality is

- a) tantric Kiya
- b) practising samadhi
- c) devotion
- d) shaktipat

5. These five functions are

- a) In tandem
- b) continuous
- c) successively repeated
- d) once and for all time

6. This knowledge that even a conditioned empirical soul is capable of all these functions same as parameshwara comes from

- a) In depth study of the Tantra
- b) Intense meditation
- c) When the guru points out these to the aspirant
- d) By shaktipat.

Sutra: Tad aprijnane sva shaktibhir vyamohitata samsaritvam

Meaning : Not knowing this (authorship of five-fold acts) leads to delusion by one's own Shaktis

(projections of consciousness) and thus the quagmire of objectivity with its reciprocations emerge

Exposition:

The empirical soul carries out the five functions just the same despite the conditionings. There is divergence of samsara due to delusion caused by one's own shaktis and thus samsaritvam. Without the knowledge of one's own five functions like Parameshwara there will be no acquisition of one's own spiritual energy. The genesis of this knowledge in turn depends on Shaktipata (dawning of Guru's benevolence),

Unless this phenomena is experienced, one remains deluded. Delusion in this parlance refers to various axiomatic adherences to presuppositions of discursive or didactic canons be they spiritual or corporal. Kshemraja says this is falling into the samsara. In a tantra called Sarvavira it has been enunciated , *"Everyone doubts owing to his own ignorance thence accrues the trail of creation and dissolution"*.

No ignorance, no dissolution so no further creation or dissolution– these are spontaneous phenomena with which even an empirical soul can sync as he learns from the Guru that like Paramshiva he too carries out these five acts and Paramshiva is his essential nature.

Samsaritvam defined: Samsaritvam in this context is the divergence of awareness caused by doubts regarding ascertaining the purport of various scriptural and worldly traditions. People doubt because of their ignorance and thus results the process of creation, dissolution etc. To explain this Kshemraja given an analogy of a peg, " as if the person is stuck with a peg of doubts regarding the scriptural or worldly traditions". If one is stuck with a nail one can't move . In the same way the intelligence gets stagnant with some scriptural or worldly notion and thus can't sublimate. This is esoteric samsaritvam and this happens when the Shaktis don't reveal their essential nature i.e doership of these five funtions.

Being deluded by one's own shaktis is explained in three ways:

(Explanation 1- In Shambav context)

Shakti defined: All mantras are alphabet and all alphabet are pertaining to Shiva. The ParaVak Shakti as different from the conscious Prakash is always prevalent in the form of great mantra 'Aham'. She contains all alphabets from a to ksh (or ha) in form of a chakra. This is the state of pure subjective awareness and contains 36 tattvas within her womb. This Parashakti gets grosser and descends to the levels of Pasyanti etc. and carries out the experience of objectivity. Pasyanti does not unveil her real nature but generates ideations of maya pramata which at this level are indistinct and uncommon states of expression of meaning and are new-new every moment. It is in this state that shaktis like Brahmi etc. manifest which in the case of 'Pashu' a bonded one cause the divergence of creation and sustenance (vikalpa-kriya). Thus the ignorant lot are deluded by these shaktis.

On the contrary in the case of 'Pati' these shaktis converge differences and dissolve. During the difference they account for the dissolution (samhar) and during the unity or absence of multiplicity cause creation and sustenance. Thus while non-dual they cause creation and sustenance. As they do this successively by eliminating vikalpas they unveil the state of 'no imagery or ideation' (avikalpa) where the awareness is submerged in the bliss of consciousness and generates the power of pure vikalpa thence the delusion and worldly divergence accrues but in this trance of Bhairava unison "One who knows that all this is my projection or grandeur remains in state of Mahesha or the great lord even when divergent and extrovert"

(Mahesha=Universal Soul)

(Explanation 2- From Shakta Context)

Chit-shakti is called Vameshvari because of her vomiting the phenomena (vaman) an acronym for creation, owing to the agreeable disposition of Samsara (vama means agreeable). The Vameshvari manifests as various moods and emotions in the minds of experients. As this happens in the state of 'Pashu' she resorts to the abode of void (shunya-pad) and manifests as the chakras like Khecari, Gocari, Dikchari and Bhucari.

1. In Khecari chakra the essential nature of pervading the ether of consciousness is veiled. This chakra is of the nature of kala Shakti which accounts for a conditioning of doership
2. Gocari chakra is the presiding deity of various internal and external senses which accounts for the thought constructs of 'multiplicity', 'ego', 'choices' and 'volition'. She is so called because she conceals her essential nature comprising of non-duality etc.
3. Dikcari chakra is her manifestation in which she conceals her essential nature of non dual disposition.
4. As Bhucari chakra she veils her nature of being 'the universal self' and thus limiting the experience of a confined appearance.

This was about the delusive nature of these chakras in case of a pashu or a bonded soul.

Now the same in the case of 'pati' becomes his shaktis in the following manner

1. Khecari- By bestowing omnipotence
2. Gocari – By a firm commitment of non-duality
3. Dikcari- By bestowing the awareness of non-duality
4. Bhucari- By bestowing the awareness of non dual composition of the objective world

These chakras "blossom the hearts of Pati" i.e. delimit his conditioning as a pashu which cause his beastly plight. In case of a Pati this happens spontaneously as a result of innate chamatkara and not as a result of some action or effort. Knowing and non knowing these shaktis like Vama etc. cause emanation and bondage respectively since they pertain to the awareness of external and internal senses of complete and uninterrupted phenomena. This is how the delusion caused by one's own shaktis cause the divergence and entanglement into the gross objective phenomena.

(Explanation 3-From Anava context)

The all conscious Parmeshvara has just one Aishvarya Shakti (the power of grandeur) which is inseparable and performs the phenomena of sphuratta or projection of consciousness into the form of various manifestations.

In the condition of a pashu when she veils her essential nature and manifests as vital airs like pran, apan and saman etc which are related with states like waking dream etc. cause delusion by identification with body, prana and puriyastaka etc. But when the middle passage blooms or udan Shakti unfolds and turiya state dawns or turyatita state dawns pertaining to vyana then even while identifying with gross body the state of pati dawns which results in Jeevanmukti (emancipation even while alive)

In this manner the process of delusion of the empirical soul or pashu has been explained in three ways. In the ninth aphorism (sutra) it was said that a tainted pramata is sansari who is actually the conscious effulgence in a contracted form, but in this sutra the same process of contraction had been enunciated in a different manner. In the present context the cause of delusion is due to misgivings of one's own shaktis. When this delusion doesn't take place then in the state of perpetual disillusionment one becomes Parmameshvara or Shiv Bhattarak embodied by the dictum of revelations- the undeluded experience is shiva only and not some intermediate states of shivahood. Such adepts are Lord Shiva concealed in a human body.

It is also said in the gloss of Pratyabhijna, "Those who meditate on a ghata etc or even their own bodies as the embodiment of Shiva comprising of 36 tattvas also attain perfection".

Questions:

1. Sansaritam or The worldly delusion caused by ones shaktis is

- a) shaktis cheating on an aspirants
- b) shaktis favouring some one else
- c) divergence that conceals the essential nature
- d) doubts pertaining to worldly and
- e) Spiritual adherence which grip an aspirants .
- f) None

2. The word vama in Vamacharanam as the ways of the world means

- a) leftist orgy
- b) hedonism
- c) aesthetic beauty

d) none

3. Shaktis like Brahmi etc manifest in

a) madhyama

b) pashyanti

c) Para

d) none

4. These shaktis delude a pashu and not a pati

a) true

b) false

c) can't say

5. Identifying erroneously with vital airs like prana.apana.samana.udana etc. The states of waking etc or puriyastakam is the delusion caused by ones shaktis

a) Yes

b) No

c) Can't say

6. A man upon attaining the trance of bhairav feels that

a) Nothing else exists

b) Everything is my expansion .

c) Any amount of divergence and ideation does not marr his shivahood .

7. A man who considers his body as made from 36 elements and thus is the embodiment of Shiva also attain completion .

a) True

b) False

c) can't say



Spider and I Weave Our Dreams by Ambika Talwar

Spider and I Weave Our Dreams

How vast the innocent playpen of my dreams,

habits I have worn since time's relentless passage.

Same old rain, drought, and tender dew it seems
has gathered tales to revive age-old memes

of creation-dissolution nature's ineluctable dressage.

How vast the rising playpen of lost dreams,
wherein particles of you floated in gorgeous streams:

miles of forests, sky, night's windowless baggage,

same old stars, storms, dews, lost language it seems.

Somehow floated away a shadow with dancing beams

when water from crystal mountain melted away an adage.

How vast the scattered playpen of my new found dreams.

Held in your palms an offering of love's extremes

so we discover the transcendent and the savage—

same old stars glinting as diamond and dew it seems.

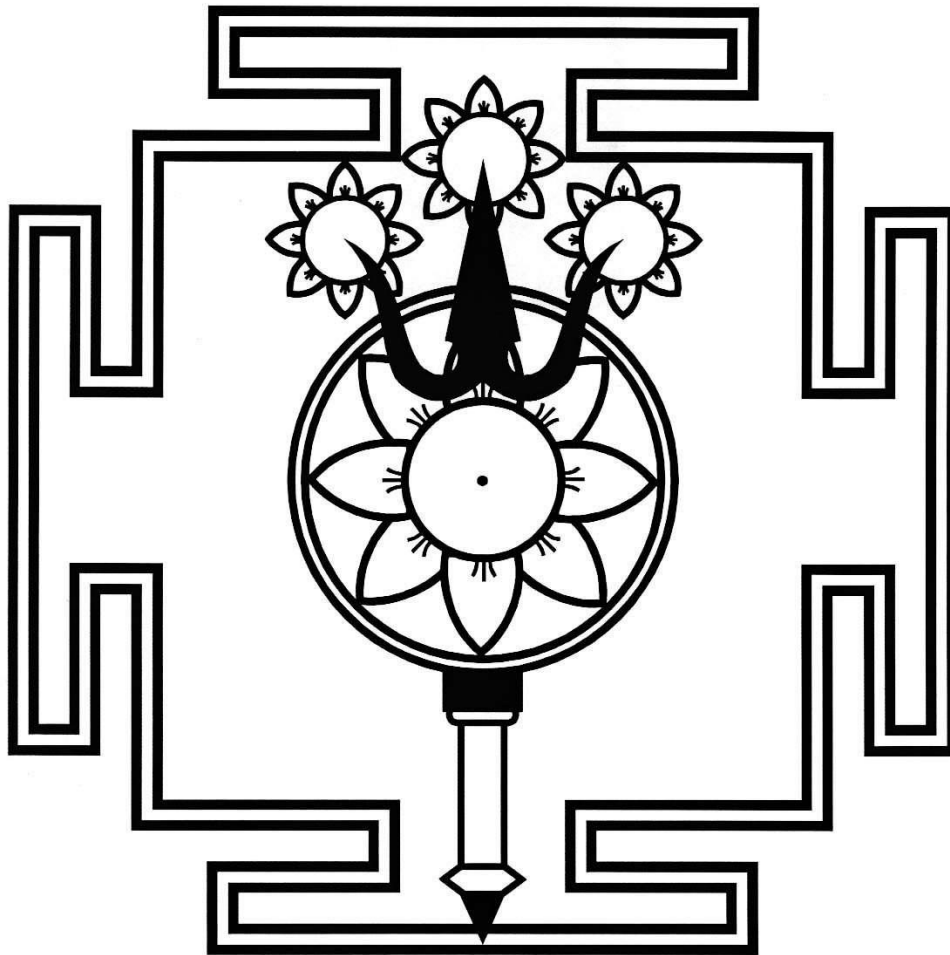
Spider's weaves however far or near at playful seams

shine as cosmic game of care and caution— Oh do no damage!

To this vast and narrow playpen of my dreams—

same old rain, storm, drought, tender dew it seems.

(Prof. Ambika talwar is a poetess of Indian origin so her compilations are interlaced with an undercurrent of eastern mysticism . The dream weaver spider urnnabhi is an ancient analogy of the creator whose dream materialises as our concrete phenomena .)



YTA Yoga Tantra and Agama(Inc)

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Paranand Swami
F-1602, The Resorts
BPTP Greater Faridabad
Haryana .India .121002.
Email: swamiparanand@gmail.com

